Family & identity

Challenge social judgement

1 Cousin Kate: the idea

Rossetti's abandoned speaker addresses the cousin who married the lord. The son gives her a final source of pride and power.

Glove simile exposes disposability. Direct address makes her account angry and persuasive.

2 Cousin Kate: the method

Six eight-line stanzas delay the revelation of the child. Public shame contrasts with maternal affection.

Victorian class, inheritance and sexual double standards explain unequal judgement. Her claims about Kate remain one speaker's view.

Negotiate independence

3 Catrin: the idea

Birth → Physical separation

Growing up → Emotional bond

Clarke connects childbirth with a later argument over skating. The cord becomes a metaphor for continuing attachment.

Love and conflict coexist: mother and daughter seek separate identities without losing their bond.

4 Catrin: the method

Two unequal stanzas link past and present. Free verse and enjambment carry complicated feeling across boundaries.

Clinical squares contrast with emotional circles. Motherhood is voiced from lived experience; neither side simply wins.

Revalue an imperfect past

5 Origin Story: the idea

Ewing recounts her parents' meeting through a comic book, then uses fragile paper to explore their love.

A comic may be preserved or worn through use. An ended relationship can still leave value through the child.

6 Origin Story: the method

Two free-verse stanzas move from family narrative to reflection. Lists contrast protection with lived enjoyment.

Chicago and Black family experience give personal history significance. Compare Cousin Kate's defiance with this affectionate reassessment.